

The Tanuki's Tidy-Up

The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with wisdom and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.



The Tanuki's Tidy-Up

Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only kinder ideas to try.

Before you begin

It was festival day in the Lantern Village, the brightest day of the whole year. All morning the market had been getting ready: stalls of painted paper fans, baskets heaped with plums and pears and golden persimmons, and long rows of paper lanterns waiting to glow. Cherry petals drifted on the breeze, and everyone hummed with excitement.

Nobody hummed more than Pon the Tanuki. He was so happy, so round, and so very bouncy, that he simply could not keep still. He rolled. He bounced. He tumbled head over heels right down the middle of the market, and one by one, every single stall went over with a clatter. When the dust settled, the fans, the fruit, and the lanterns lay in one enormous jumble, and poor Pon sat in the middle of it with his ears flat and his heart full of sorry.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper, who knew every story in the mountains, called the two of you to her side. "You have clever heads and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more today than the strongest pair of arms. Will you help Pon set the market right before the festival opens?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a ball of bright red thread, a little bronze bell, and a soft, sweet rice cake. "Remember," she said with a smile, "in these mountains we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being wise, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Wisdom, Courage, or Kindness?

Stop 1: The Jumbled Stalls

You hurried to the market square, and there in the very middle of the muddle sat Pon the Tanuki. His ears drooped. His round nose wobbled. A fat tear sat ready to fall. "I have spoiled the whole festival," he sniffed. "I only ever wanted to help, and I have made everything worse."

He was so sad and so flustered that he could not have tidied a single fan. Before any sorting could begin, Pon needed a friend.

What could you do to help Pon feel better? You might sit down beside him, or tell him that everybody knocks things over sometimes, or remind him that a muddle is much smaller when friends fix it together. What do you try?

When your kind words reached him, Pon wiped his nose on the back of his paw and gave a small, brave smile. "You are good friends to me," he said. "A muddle is not so big after all. Come on, let us tidy up together." And up he jumped, ready to put right every single thing.

Stop 2: The Great Sort

Now you looked properly at the heap, and what a heap it was. Fans, fruit, and lanterns lay all tangled together in one great mountain of muddle, and every last thing had to find its proper home before the festival could open.

The painted fans belonged, fanned out in their neat rows, on the fan stall. The plums and pears and persimmons belonged sorted into their baskets on the fruit stall. The paper lanterns belonged, one by one, upon the lantern posts that lined the square. To set it right you would have to sort, and count, and match, with calm and careful heads.

How will you bring order to all this? You might make a separate pile for each kind of thing, or count the right number of lanterns onto each post, or match every fruit to its basket by its colour. What is your plan?

Patiently, piece by piece, you sorted and counted it all back into place, and slowly the market grew tidy and bright again. Pon watched in wonder and clapped his small paws together. "You are so clever and so calm," he said. "I would have rushed and made it worse, but you thought it all the way through."

Stop 3: The Last Lantern

The market looked almost perfect now, every fan and fruit and lantern in its place. Almost. For when you looked up at the heart of the square, you saw that the grandest lantern of all was missing: the big red festival lantern that hung high over the very middle, the one whose glow was the signal for the festival to begin. Without it, the drum could not sound.

Just then, Kon the Fox came trotting out of the bamboo with a leaf upon his head and a clever twinkle in his eye. "I am rather good at noticing things," he said. "And I do believe I saw something round and red go rolling away, down the lane, under the old plum tree by the bridge. Follow my clue, and think where a runaway lantern likes to hide."

Where could the last lantern have rolled to? You might follow Kon's clue to the plum tree, or ask Pon, who knows every corner of the market, to help you search. And how will you help Pon feel proud instead of ashamed? What do you do?

You followed the clue down the lane, and there, snug under the drooping plum tree, sat the great red lantern, quite unharmed. As you lifted it up, Pon came bounding over, and it was Pon who pointed out the very branch it had caught on. "I knew where it would roll," he said, and for the first time all day he stood up tall and proud. "I helped after all." Together you carried the lantern back and hung it high in its rightful place.

The Festival Opens

The market was set right at last, and oh, how it shone. Every fan was fanned in its row, every basket of fruit sat neat and gleaming, and every paper lantern glowed warm and golden in its place, with the great red festival lantern burning brightest of all in the very middle of the square.

Pon the Tanuki was forgiven, and far better than forgiven, he was proud. The big drum began to beat, the villagers came laughing and dancing into the square, and with a happy ring the festival opened at last.

High above the blossom mountains, Amaterasu the Sun-Kami looked down through the warm light and smiled. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your wisdom, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Well done, heroes of the Lantern Village.

The Story in Pictures



A jolly round tanuki looking worried among toppled festival stalls with fruit, fans and lanterns jumbled together, two small heroes arriving.



Two small heroes and a happy tanuki sorting festival goods back into the right stalls, counting fans and fruit and lanterns into neat rows.



A friendly fox offering a clue to two small heroes searching for one last lost festival lantern among blossom trees.



A tidy festival market all set right at dusk, neat stalls and glowing lanterns, a happy tanuki and two small heroes admiring it together.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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